and institutional channels for discussion and debate of policies and laws as the forums for direct democracy in Cuba.[41]

Cubans also emphasize that U.S. aggression has served to limit democratic possibilities in their country. In particular, the reality of U.S. interference has contributed to government sanctions against independent political organizing: "A scenario of negotiation and lessening tensions between the United States and Cuba could allow the Cuban political system to overcome these restrictions. If the United States would renounce its internal political activities in Cuba, this would mean that Cuba could allow a loyal opposition to develop."[42]

Cuban analysts, however, are by no means uncritical of their country's political and economic institutions. There is an important current of opinion within Cuba that, while still rejecting U.S. conceptions of liberal democracy, coincides with liberal conceptions in some areas such as calling for a free and critical press, and greater tolerance of differing political positions. "Democratization must inevitably include the strengthening of the spaces for participation that allow the common citizen to influence decisions that affect their lives, to take part in debates regarding national directions, to have an effective control over their representatives, and have access to the necessary and relevant information. In sum: to move from being a mere consumer of policies to being an active producer of policy."[43] Cuban scholars clearly distinguish between criticism from the right, which rejects the socialist experience entirely, "basing their criticism on supposed universal values of the model of so-called representative democracy, based upon private property, a multi-party system, electoral trafficking [el comercio electoral], and individual freedoms," and those from the left, "which include internal criticisms that party activists, academics, political leaders and the Cuban population have about the Cuban political system" and call for a "more diversified, decentralized and depersonalized power structure" and whose goal is to "preserve revolutionary power and develop a participatory democracy."[44]

Thus there is an important voice among Cuban intellectuals that from a position of support for the Revolution calls for greater political space